

Imperial Knights — LSO List A Runbook

Version 2.0 · 2026-07-28

Mindset

Knights are 'always outnumbered, rarely outgunned.' At a 300+ GT, START every hard matchup from the EXPECTATION OF A LOSS and hunt the HEIST. Model the opponent playing OPTIMALLY. Realistic goal: a strong POSITIVE record + steal a couple you shouldn't win — not winning the event. The 2 Volcano lances win the shooting phase; the Lancer wins the melee phase you can't tank; you win the game on the mission (out-OC where you can).

Weighted ~46%. The disposition (Purge the Foe) decides the shape of your day: you WANT Priority-Assets

opponents (you get Destroyer's Wrath — kill for VP) and you DREAD Take-and-Hold opponents

(Unstoppable Force asks you to hold objectives a 6-model army can't). Kill their scoring units to steal the

control you can't muscle.

Tapestry quick-reference

Rule	What it does
Ion Shield	5++ invuln vs SHOOTING ONLY (ranged). Does NOTHING in melee.
Rotate Ion Shields	VALOURSTRIKE 1CP STRATAGEM: +1 to a Knight's invulnerable save vs SHOOTING (5++ -> 4++) for the phase. The core durability lever in the hard shooting matchups — cycle it onto the focused Knight each turn. (Stratagems ARE the detachment: how Valourstrike actually plays.)
Questoris/Dominus melee	NO melee invuln (verified — printed 5+* is 'vs ranged attacks only') — bare 3+ armour in the fight phase. Melee is the universal Knight weakness (only the Sanctuary enhancement adds a melee 5++).
Cerastus Lancer	VERIFIED 415pts, M14 T11 W28, 4++ invuln vs ALL attacks (no asterisk). Shock lance STRIKE 5A WS2+ S20 AP-3 D8 [Lance] (wounds anything <=T12 on 2s) / SWEEP 10A S10 AP-2 D3. Shock Charge = free Tank Shock (0CP) on the charge. Character-assassin: standalone monster/Titanic characters DIRECTLY; ATTACHED characters via EPIC CHALLENGE (1CP core strat -> [PRECISION] in melee). No Knight GUN has Precision -> you canNOT snipe attached characters at range.
Volcano lance	VERIFIED 72" D3 SHOTS (avg 2), S18 AP-5 D6+8 [Blast] — ~23 dmg/turn; one-shots no-invuln anchors (Hammerheads T10, Land Raiders T12, Kataphrons, Shadowsword, no-invuln Norns/Emissaries). Overkill into low-W chaff. The Castellán is 425/450 pts (escalating: 1st 425, 2nd 450 — MFM).

Bold Gallantry (Valourstrike)	Any Knight Advances -> ALL Knight ranged weapons gain [ASSAULT] army-wide that turn (advance-and-shoot).
Rain of Devastation (Dominus)	Dominus Knights' attacks vs a unit in a terrain area get +1 to hit.
Super-Heavy Walker	Movement-only. NO Knight falls back and shoots — an engaged Knight instead shoots OUT of combat at -1 to hit (tar-pit costs -1).
What beats Knights	(1) invuln-NEGATION: Anti-Vehicle/Monster X+ (wound regardless of S) + Devastating Wounds (crit->mortal); (2) massed AP-2+ VOLUME (5++ fails 68%); (3) MELEE into the no-invuln fight phase; (4) out-OC / out-score.
Helverin Bondsman (EVERY TURN)	Keep the Armiger Helverin within Bondsman range of the KNIGHT CRUSADER -> Crusader's Duty = +1 to hit = BS2+ on its 8 autocannon shots (48"). It is your SAFE backfield/home OC6 anchor + Suppression (-1 to hit its target) -- do NOT push it forward, and don't let it drift out of the Crusader's bond.
Killing characters (NO Precision on any Knight)	You CANNOT target a Character attached to a Bodyguard unit — every wound goes to the bodyguard (no Knight GUN has [PRECISION], so you canNOT snipe at range). Tools: (1) EPIC CHALLENGE (core strat 15.03, 1CP): in the FIGHT phase a Knight CHARACTER's melee weapons gain [PRECISION] -> the Lancer (5x S20 AP-3 D8) charges the unit and deletes the attached character. (2) STANDALONE Monster/Vehicle/Titanic characters (Fulgrim, Magnus, Lion, Daemon Princes, Steel-Hammer superheavies, enemy Knights) = shoot/fight DIRECTLY, no strat. (3) Clear a SMALL bodyguard whole to expose the character. (4) Lone Operatives = only targetable within 12".
CP economy (verify against list-building)	~2 CP/round (1 at the start of EACH player-turn), ~10/game; + rare discard-a-secondary (max +1/turn) + CP-granting models. Each Strat is once/phase and costs CP. Rotate Ion Shields (1CP) and Epic Challenge (1CP) COMPETE each turn — plan the spend. HONOURED (Code Chivalric Deed completed) = +2 CP (3 if you rolled the Oath), exempt from the per-round cap -> a real CP engine; completing a Deed EARLY funds Rotate + Epic Challenge all game.
Code Chivalric (the Oath — pick per matchup)	1 Deed + 1 Quality at deploy. QUALITY (army-wide, all game): MARTIAL VALOUR (re-roll 1 hit + 1 wound shoot/fight = the shooting amplifier, DEFAULT) / LEGACY (+2 OC, +1 Ld = the out-OC fix vs hordes) / EAGER (+2" M, +1 Adv & Charge = land the Lancer + out-manoeuve). DEED (complete once -> Honoured +2/3CP): REAP A TALLY (destroy > round-number units this round — fast for a gun list) / LAY LOW THE TYRANT (kill a named enemy CHARACTER — only vs a STANDALONE/Titanic linchpin you can actually kill, or an attached one the Lancer can Epic-Challenge) / RECLAIM THE REALM (out-OC them — AVOID, you're usually out-OC'd). See CODE_CHIVALRIC for the per-archetype picks.
Battle-shock — the wounded- Knight trap	Core 01.07 + the rulebook's own VEHICLE example: a single-model unit BELOW HALF its Wounds must take a battle-shock roll (Ld) every Command phase. A damaged Castellan (<12 of 24W), Crusader (<11 of 22), Lancer (<14 of 28) or Helverin (<6 of 12) therefore rolls each turn, and on a FAIL it (a) has OC '-' (0) so it stops holding objectives, (b) CANNOT be targeted by stratagems -> you canNOT Rotate Ion Shields it the very turn it's hurt and most needs the 4++, and (c) can't do Actions. So a hurt Knight can be locked out of its own durability lever. Mitigate: LEGACY UNSULLIED Quality (+1 Ld eases the roll) and INSANE BRAVERY (core 15.04, 1CP: auto-pass ONE test — save it for the Knight you MUST Rotate

next turn). WEAPONIZED at LSO by Tyranids (Shadow in the Warp forces ALL your units to test, on 3D6 near synapse), Necrons (1CP C'tan strat, forced test at -1 + D3+1 mortals), CSM and Chaos Daemons (Fear/forced tests). Vs those decks, keep a Knight either above half or above-half-and-screened, and bank a CP for Insane Bravery.

Per-matchup battle plans (28 archetypes)

Necrons — 36% (Unfavourable) · you play **Meatgrinder vs their Purge the Foe (they play Meatgrinder)**

Deciding factor: 54 gauss cannons S7 AP-2 D2 Lethal (~kills a Knight/turn through Rotate) + un-killable Void Dragon (4+/-1Dmg/reanim) + reanimation refunds chip + out-OC.

Mission / heist: ['Erase a full 6-model Destroyer unit T1 (Volcano/thermal — T6/no-invuln) — each removed = ~12 anti-Knight dmg off the table.', 'Rotate the focused Knight every turn; body-block so a 2nd Knight is never offered.', 'Do NOT chase the Void Dragon (tar pit that heals off your hulls) — screen it away from melee; Lancer duels/pins it.', 'Win on tempo/objectives before the reanimate economy buries you. ~20-30% game — a heist, not a matchup.']

Kill priority: Lokhust Destroyer units -> Reanimators -> soft characters (NOT the Void Dragon).

Deploy: Terrain/LOS so the gunline sees ONE Knight at a time. Volcano priority = the Destroyers, not the C'tan.

Necrons — 22% (Unfavourable) · you play **Unstoppable Force vs their Take and Hold (they play Immovable Object)**

Deciding factor: 3 un-killable C'tan (4+/-1Dmg/Reanim). Nominally I out-hold OC4 with OC10 — BUT they're M10 FLY and reanimate, so 'out-OC' is shakier than it looks; win on POINTS not tabling, and don't over-trust the OC math.

Mission / heist: ['Screen the Void Dragon (Anti-Vehicle 2+ wounds any Knight on 2s + heals off your hulls) away from melee.', 'Lancer duels/pins the Nightbringer (4++ trades favourably; keeps the Dev scythe off a Questoris).', 'Focus-fire ONE C'tan per turn to the floor (chip is refunded — overkill past reanimation); never split.', 'Win the OBJECTIVE race: OC10/OC6 vs OC4, Tank Shock, out-hold. Grindy points win.']

Kill priority: None of the 3 C'tan get tabled — out-hold. Snipe Szeras / Skorpekh Lords if they lose Lone-Op screening.

Deploy: Play the mission, not the dice. Contest/flip the C'tan's objective with OC10.

Necrons — 33% (Unfavourable) · you play **Unstoppable Force vs their Take and Hold (they play Immovable Object)**

Deciding factor: 3x Monolith T13 W22 2+ NO invuln + reanim. Monoliths ARE killable (Volcano wounds T13 on 3+, AP-5 through 2+; shieldbreaker Anti-Titanic 4+). 12 death rays chunk.

Mission / heist: ['Concentrate ALL fire on ONE Monolith/turn — remove it outright (~27-33 focused beats ~2 reanim); never chip.', 'Kill the Silent King early (reroll-1s + move engine, killable T10 W16).', 'Rotate every turn; the Monoliths are M8 slow — kite and out-manoeuve.']

Kill priority: One Monolith at a time -> Silent King -> the rest.

Deploy: Concentrate-to-kill; spreading fire feeds reanimation.

Dark Angels — >60% (Lean favourable) · you play **Punishment vs their Disruption (they play Delaying Action)**

Deciding factor: 27 supercharged plasma talons (S9 AP-3 D2) + Chaplain 'Catechism of Fire' = Dev-Wound plasma (bypasses ion shield) + ~90 M12 bikes out-OC + fall-back-and-shoot.

Mission / heist: ["Kill the STORM SPEEDER THUNDERSTRIKE first (Volcano) — it's the +1-to-wound MARK engine that makes the plasma volume lethal; remove it and the alpha drops from 'dead Knight' to 'chunked'.", 'Deny the 9" bubble: deploy behind LoS blockers >24" back; keeping bikes >9" drops plasma from RF (3 shots -> 2) and halves the Dev math.', 'Delete whole Black Knight packs with Avenger/thermal/RFBC BEFORE they get Catechism range; pop the 3 ATVs + Scouts (deny actions).', 'Lancer = backfield linebacker hunting Scouts/ATVs/Command (not a centre dive — expect it kited by fall-back-shoot). Wall lanes with the hulls; win the ONE point OC10 owns. Bottom-tier matchup.']

Kill priority: Storm Speeder Thunderstrike (mark engine) -> Black Knight packs -> ATVs -> Scouts.

Deploy: LoS-block deep; their alpha is huge (Recon-Hunter Scouts 9" + M12 + Assault).

Dark Angels — >33% (Unfavourable) · you play **Unstoppable Force vs their Take and Hold (they play Immovable Object)**

Deciding factor: 3x un-tableable OC1 bricks (W4 2+/4++ -1Dmg + Armour of Contempt) — but I OUT-OC with OC10, and the killable scorers (Repulsor W16 no-invuln, Eradicators, Sternguard) die to my guns.

Mission / heist: ["Out-OC: an OC10 Knight beats a whole OC5-8 brick on any objective — don't try to table the bricks, out-hold them.", 'Delete the Repulsor (W16, dead in a turn), Eradicators + Sternguard + Scouts (W2-3) with volume guns.', 'Never feed a Knight into a brick's charge — shoot OUT at -1 or fall back; Lancer counter-charges.', 'Win the primary on raw OC.']

Kill priority: Repulsor -> Eradicators -> Sternguard -> Scouts (the killable scorers; ignore the bricks).

Deploy: Screen the Deathwing deep-strike (Navigator dome); out-OC bodies.

Space Wolves — >24% (Unfavourable) · you play **Unstoppable Force vs their Take and Hold (they play Immovable Object)**

Deciding factor: 8 Assault-Terminator thunder hammers (S8 AP-2 D2 DEV) crack the no-melee-invuln Questoris (~12-14/charge); Sternguard Fusillade (Anti-Veh 5+ + Dev) punches the ion shield; out-bodies/out-OCs. (Half its melee is duds: Wulfen S5, Blood Claws S4.) OBSERVED 2026-07-25: a DIFFERENT SW build — Saga of the Beastlayer (Thunderwolf/beast-hunter) — went 5-0 at Bedburger Scheunen Kloppen. Its detachment tally targets enemy CHARACTER/MONSTER/VEHICLE units, so vs a Knight army it is a HUNTER BY DESIGN (every Knight is a VEHICLE) — a distinct, arguably nastier melee threat than this Terminator deathstar; watch for it and treat it as at-least-as-UNFAVOURABLE.

Mission / heist: ["Lancer counter-charge: its 4++ survives the hammers a Questoris can't; hold it to trade INTO a landed brick.", "BRICK-WALL CAVEAT: assassinating Logan/Ragnar/Librarians is only MARGINAL — it doesn't collapse a faceless 4++ wall. Kill a multiplier only if it strips a real buff; otherwise don't over-commit the Lancer.", 'Focus-kill one brick BEFORE it lands (deep-strike + Celerity advance-charge); screen the drop with the Navigator dome + Helverin.', 'SW terminators are M5-6 on foot — refuse-flank, out-OC where you can, race secondaries. Near hard-loss.']

Kill priority: Thunder-hammer Assault Terminators -> buff characters only if it strips a live multiplier.

Deploy: Screen deep-strike lanes; keep Knights >9" from Teleport Homers.

Blood Angels — >23% (Unfavourable) · you play **Unstoppable Force vs their Take and Hold (they play Immovable Object)**

Deciding factor: Red Thirst (+2 S/+1 A on the charge) -> Death Company S10 fists, Sanguinary Guard S8 AP-3, Dev hammers; ~15-18 into a Questoris from one DC+Lemartes charge (no melee invuln); best-in-game delivery (M12 + Deep Strike + re-roll charge + Angelic-Host re-drop).

Mission / heist: ['Deny the alpha, don't fight it: layered chaff/bubble-wrap so DC land 9"+ out, eat overwatch, can't reach T2. Castle T1-2.', 'Avenger gatling OVERWATCH the drop (A18 S6 AP-2 into 2W-T4 DC) thins it before it swings.', 'Lancer + EPIC CHALLENGE (1CP): charge the DC/Sang-Guard unit and Precision-kill the ATTACHED multiplier — Lemartes (-1 Dmg) / Sanguinary Priest (FNP5+/-1AP) / Chaplain. You CANNOT snipe them at range; alternatively clear the small unit to expose them.', 'Win on the MISSION: out-OC massively (OC10/6 vs OC1 infantry). Do NOT try to table them.']

Kill priority: Lemartes -> Sanguinary Priests -> Chaplains (the buff engine) -> Death Company as it lands.

Deploy: Navigator dome + chaff screen the deep strike; never present an unscreened Knight to a 12"+charge.

Thousand Sons — >85% (Favourable) · you play **Destroyer's Wrath vs their Priority Assets (they play Vital Link)**

Deciding factor: Psychic-MW is THROTTLED in 11E (~5/turn via Doombolt, not spam); Rubrics are warpflamer anti-infantry (bounce off Knights); AP-2 volume is only S4. MAGNUS (T11 W16 2+/4++, S16 AP-3 Dev melee, two-rounds a Questoris) is the ONLY Knight-killer.

Mission / heist: ['Refuse OR kill Magnus: screen and body-block his 14"+Time-Flux threat with an Armiger, OR dump a turn of Volcano+gatling into him (4++ + Impossible Form -1Dmg stretches it to ~2 turns).', 'Keep Ion Shields up — the rest of the list literally lacks the S/AP to punch 26-28W Knights.', 'Kill Sorcerers (throttle Doombolt) with the Avenger/RFCB; clear Rubrics/Scarab with volume.', 'Out-OC on Priority Assets. Best matchup on the board (~55-60/40).']

Kill priority: Magnus (or refuse) -> Sorcerers (the ritual engine) -> Rubric/Scarab bodies.

Deploy: Don't feed an unscreened Knight to Magnus's melee. Watch Shadow Puppeteer (-1 to hit your best gun).

Grey Knights — >52% (Coin-flip) · you play **Meatgrinder vs their Purge the Foe (they play Meatgrinder)**

Deciding factor: PRELIM — not deep-verified. Elite 2+/4++ Terminators/Paladins + psychic Smite MW + best-in-game teleport/deep-strike. Likely coin-flip -> mild-unfav for Knights (MW + melee into no-invuln fight phase), hard for Sisters.

Mission / heist: ['Kill the casters/character support to throttle the MW; screen the teleport (Navigator dome).', 'Lancer counter-charge + assassinate a Grand Master/Librarian; out-OC (their bodies are few/OC1).', 'NEEDS A FULL PASS before LSO — treat as provisional.']

Kill priority: Casters/characters -> Paladins/Terminators. (Provisional.)

Deploy: Screen deep-strike; provisional.

Chaos Space Marines — >41% (Lean unfavourable) · you play **Consecrate vs their Reconnaissance (they play Triangulation)**

Deciding factor: Record built on OBJECTIVES, not killing Knights. Anti-Knight is CONCENTRATED and killable: Vashtorr (Anti-Veh 4+ Dev hammer + +2 S aura to a Daemon-Vehicle Defiler) + Lord Discordant (free MW faucet). Dark Pacts = Lethal Hits.

Mission / heist: ['T1: Lancer + a Volcano into VASHTORR before he beds into the Defiler's 3" Lone-Op bubble — one kill, two problems (he's the assassin AND the Defiler's +2 S battery).', 'Kill the Lord Discordant next (T9 W10 4++) to shut off the free MW + wound-reroll enabler.', 'Delete the killable chassis (Rhinos/bikes/Noise Marines); never sit engaged ON an objective (+1 AP near objectives).', 'Out-tempo (you can't out-spread on Recon) — ~50/50.']

Kill priority: Vashtorr -> Lord Discordant -> Defiler -> killable scorers.

Deploy: Don't clump kills near a Vengeance-style reactive piece; watch Dark-Pact Lethal Hits.

Emperor's Children — >42% (Lean unfavourable) · you play **Destroyer's Wrath vs their Priority Assets (they play Vital Link)**

Deciding factor: Elite MELEE. Fulgrim (T11 W16 2+/4++, -1 to hit, Fights First) deletes a Knight/turn AND shrugs your guns (~2 dmg/Volcano shot). Defiler + Flawless Blades (AP-4) butcher. Thrill Seekers = advance-and-charge threat ranges.

Mission / heist: ['CONCEDE Fulgrim: body-block his lane with an Armiger/wreck so he reaches ONE target/turn, never the same Knight twice. Do NOT Rotate vs him (useless in melee) and do NOT try to kill him.', 'T1-2: shoot the SUPPORT melee off before it connects — Defiler (5++, no -1-to-hit, dies to concentrated Volcano/thermal), then Flawless Blades + Noise Marines with the Avenger.', 'Win on PRIMARY: Priority Assets, OC10 Questoris sit on objectives; Lancer runs down the cheap OC screen (Spawn/Noise Marines) — trade a Knight/turn to Fulgrim while out-scoring the defanged swarm.', 'Close primary loss / draw-range if executed; blowout if Fulgrim reaches two Knights a turn.']

Kill priority: Defiler -> Flawless Blades -> Noise Marines / Infractors (NOT Fulgrim).

Deploy: Screen Fulgrim's lane (standalone Monster — shootable, but a 4++/Fights-First beatstick, so avoid melee). Use the Lancer + EPIC CHALLENGE (1CP) to Precision-kill an ATTACHED Lord Exultant in melee — not Fulgrim.

Drukhari — >58% (Lean favourable) · you play **Consecrate vs their Reconnaissance (they play Triangulation)**

Deciding factor: Durability mismatch in MY favour: Volcano one-shots their no-invuln Raiders/Ravagers (T8-9); their Incubi/Exhibition Lethal Hits are NON-Vehicle (don't touch Knights); no haywire = thin invuln-bypass. 13 dark lances chip ~1 Knight/turn but can't table me.

Mission / heist: ['Kill the two Scourge units (8 of 13 lances) first, then the Ravager (Volcano one-shots) and Lady Malys.', 'Rotate the focused Knight (make their lances fail on 1/2, not 2/3).', 'Contest-don't-chase: they out-spread me on Recon with ~90 fast bodies — plant OC10 on the 2-3 objectives that matter, gun their scorers off the rest.', 'Weather the T2 lance alpha (hull-down T1) and grind their paper army off T3-5.']

Kill priority: Scourges -> Ravager (lances) -> Lady Malys -> Raiders/Venoms.

Deploy: Reserve/hull-down T1 to blunt the lance alpha; don't over-expose.

Adeptus Custodes — >45% (Coin-flip) · you play **Unstoppable Force vs their Take and Hold (they play Immovable Object)**

Deciding factor: 'So few models' (~40, tanky-per-model 2+/4++ but W2-4). Anti-Knight is THIN (one Caladius ~6/turn; guardian spears S7 wound me on 5+). Might of the Moritoi is Walker-only = dead (no Dreadnoughts). I OUT-OC (OC10 vs OC2) + grind them off.

Mission / heist: ['Volume guns (Avenger A18 / RFBC / plasma) into the Custodian bodies — do NOT Volcano a W3 Custodian (overkill); save Volcano/thermal for the Caladius + characters.', 'Lancer SWEEP (A10 S10 AP-2

D3) chews Custodes squads (wounds T6 on 2+).', 'Out-OC every objective (OC10 vs OC2) and table their ~40 models over the game — the removal race is winnable.', 'Just dodge their melee (S5-7 butchers if it connects).']

Kill priority: Caladius (their one gun) -> characters -> bodies with volume.

Deploy: Out-body/out-OC; right gun per target (volume into bodies, big guns into the tank).

Leagues of Votann — >76% (Favourable) · you play **Destroyer vs their Priority Assets (they play Vital Link)**

Deciding factor: Judgement Tokens DON'T exist in 11E (army rule = Prioritised Efficiency, +1 Hit near objectives). Their SHOOTING can't crack me (2 Heavy magna-rail cannons). The danger is the deep-striking Cthonian Beserk maul-swarm — mauls have ANTI-VEHICLE 3+ (wound me on 3s) in the no-melee-invuln fight phase.

Mission / heist: ['Never expose a lone Questoris to a 9" Beserk drop-charge (re-rollable via Yield Points): screen with the Armiger, hug terrain, keep big Knights back T1-2.', 'Kill BOTH Land Fortresses T1-2 (T12 W16 no-invuln — Volcano ~one-shots) -> removes their entire anti-tank; then their shooting is harmless.', 'My guns delete the T6 W1 Beserks wholesale (feet + gatling); Lancer 4++ tanks the maul swarm and breaks blocks.', 'Race the clock before they hit 7 Yield Points; contest, don't sit.']

Kill priority: Land Fortresses -> Berehk / Kahl -> Beserks with volume.

Deploy: Screen the deep-strike landing zones; a Beserk that can't charge does nothing.

Tyranids — >34% (Unfavourable) · you play **Unstoppable Force vs their Take and Hold (they play Immovable Object)**

Deciding factor: 5 Norns (T11 W16, M10) with Singular Purpose OC15 ANCHORS (out-hold me), harpoon melee (S12 AP-3 into no-invuln Questoris), and healing. Emissaries have NO invuln (Volcano one-shots); Assimilators are 4++.

Mission / heist: ['Focus-kill the no-invuln Emissaries at RANGE (Volcano/thermal one-shot); grind the 4++ Assimilators.', 'OC15 anchors mean the primary is a KILL-RACE, not an OC race — I must physically remove the anchoring Norn to take its objective.', 'Refuse the melee gang: kite on M10-14, never let 2+ Norns pile one Knight; Lancer assassinates a Norn on the charge.', 'Kill the Neurotyrant + Zoanthropes (synapse/heal/psychic engine); win on kills + secondaries.']

Kill priority: Emissaries (no-invuln) -> Neurotyrant / Zoanthropes -> Assimilators (grind).

Deploy: Space to deny the harpoon hook-and-charge (+2 to their charge); don't cluster.

T'au Empire — >59% (Lean favourable) · you play **Destroyer vs their Priority Assets (they play Vital Link)**

Deciding factor: The ceiling anti-Knight SHOOTING: railguns (S20 AP-5 D6+6 DEV WOUNDS — crit-mortals bypass the ion shield) + markerlight-boosted AP-3 volume + 6 Farsight fusion + rail rifles (Dev). A markerlit Kauyon alpha = ~30-40 into one Knight (dead, Rotated or not). Fire-and-Fade evasion neuters my melee.

Mission / heist: ['Kill the HAMMERHEADS (2 railguns, T10 W14 NO invuln — Volcano deletes one/turn) + the Sunforge fusion suits (T5 W4) EARLY.', 'Deny the Kauyon+markerlight alpha turn: terrain/reserves/LoS so they can't focus an un-Rotated Knight.', 'Rotate the most-lit Knight; never present a clean focus target; their guns are the wrong-shaped for chaff but Dev/railgun bypass the invuln.', 'Out-OC on Priority Assets IF I survive — their OC is modest. Expect to be behind; steal on tempo.']

Kill priority: Hammerheads (railguns) -> Sunforge (6 fusion) -> Riptides/Ghostkeels -> markerlight Pathfinders.

Deploy: Reserves + LoS-block vs the Kauyon turn; kill the mark/railgun platforms first.

Adeptus Mechanicus — 59% (Lean favourable) · you play **Destroyer's Wrath vs their Priority Assets (they play Vital Link)**

Deciding factor: Kataphron Breachers' Heavy arc rifles = ANTI-VEHICLE 4+ (wound my T11-12 on 4+ regardless of S) + Lethal Hits + Cawl reroll -> 2 bricks = ~1 dead big Knight/turn, negating both my pillars (T beaten on 4+, 5++ fails 68%). Rad-Zone = chip-MW/battle-shock, NO Toughness reduction. Out-bodied.

Mission / heist: ['Range-deny: Heavy arc rifle wants 15" (Rapid Fire 2 doubles its shots); Kataphrons are M5" SLOW. Deploy behind terrain, stay outside 15" BR1, Rotate the exposed Knight.', 'Win the race on ONE brick: Kataphrons have NO invuln/FNP -> dump all guns + a charge to remove a 6-model brick BR1-2 (cuts anti-Knight output ~40%). Don't spread fire.', 'Lancer as a wrecking ball INTO a brick (shreds T7 W3 + pins them so they shoot the Lancer, not the gun-Knights).', 'Concede the OC war; keep it close, need Hazardous plasma self-wounds + Rotate to swing.']

Kill priority: One Kataphron brick at a time -> Cawl/Manipulus (if reachable).

Deploy: Stay outside 15"; kill the first brick before it doubles up.

Orks — 54% (Coin-flip) · you play **Punishment vs their Disruption (they play Delaying Action)**

Deciding factor: Fast dakka: 18 Deffkopta rokkit + Speshul Ammo ([Anti-Vehicle 4+] wounds T11-12 on 4s regardless of S) + Mobile Dakkastorm (+2 S). ~1 Knight/turn once koptas range in; out-BODIES + out-mobiles on Disruption; my guns are the wrong shape to clear the koptas (Avenger ~2/turn; 18 koptas = 9 turns).

Mission / heist: ['Rotate-cycle to survive the focus (they kill a non-Rotated Knight; save one with the 4++).', 'Kill the tough hulls (Kill Rigs T10 W16, Wazdakka, Trukks) with the big guns — the koptas you can't out-clear.', 'Lancer contest/distraction (a 'distraction carnifex' that forces their fast wall to react).', 'Accept the underdog; steal on mobility secondaries + a lucky Rotate run.']

Kill priority: Kill Rigs -> Wazdakka -> Trukks (koptas are un-clearable — don't chase).

Deploy: Underdog. Concede the body war, race the mission.

Orks — 14% (Unfavourable) · you play **Unstoppable Force vs their Take and Hold (they play Immovable Object)**

Deciding factor: ~100-165 bodies (Mob Mentality 5++ at 10+ models, no Boyz return). 6-9 Knights CANNOT out-body / out-OC / clear it; the guns are the wrong shape. A known HARD COUNTER and a top all-comers list.

Mission / heist: ['No reliable heist — ACCEPT it as a feature of 40k, not a list flaw.', 'Play the mission, minimise the loss margin, and hope to dodge it in the Swiss.', 'Do NOT warp the list to patch this at the cost of the 90% you win.']

Kill priority: n/a — you cannot clear enough.

Deploy: Accept the matchup; a respectable loss is the goal.

Space Marines (Salamanders) — 45% (Coin-flip) · you play **Unstoppable Force vs their Take and Hold (they play Immovable Object)**

Deciding factor: Their durability is a PAPER TIGER vs Knight guns: Land Raiders T12 W16 2+ NO invuln (Volcano ~one-shots), everything else W2-3. Flamers do nothing to T11-13. Anti-Knight spikes to ~15-22 ONLY if I feed a Knight <12" into an Immolation-Protocols Dev flamer dump.

Mission / heist: ['Kill BOTH Land Raiders T1-2 (Volcano/thermal — no invuln) -> strips their army fast.', 'Respect the 12" flamer bubble — space >12" and their anti-Knight collapses to ~2-4.', 'Grind the W2-3 bricks off with volume; out-durable + out-gun. Good-to-very-good matchup.']

Kill priority: Land Raiders -> Vulkan / multi-meltas -> infantry.

Deploy: Stay >12" from the flamer bricks; delete the taxis first.

Chaos Knights — >41% (Lean unfavourable) · you play **Consecrate vs their Reconnaissance (they play Triangulation)**

Deciding factor: Mirror — same chassis (S20 shock lances both ways) + Chaos adds Dreadblades / dark rites / War Dog melee packs. User is CONFIDENT ('Chaos Knights are struggling'). Not deep-verified.

Mission / heist: ['Mirror fundamentals: Rotate, out-shoot with the 2 Castellans, Lancer duels their Lancer/War Dogs.', 'Out-OC with the Questoris; kill their gun-Knights first (Volcano trades up).', 'PRELIMINARY — user-confident, low priority. Full pass only if it trends up.']

Kill priority: Their gun-Knights -> War Dog packs. (Provisional.)

Deploy: Mirror; provisional.

T'au Empire — >36% (Unfavourable) · you play **Meatgrinder vs their Purge the Foe (they play Meatgrinder)**

Deciding factor: The DOMINANT T'au build in the sample (5/75). Deep-strike alpha: 4-5 Commanders + Crisis Sunforge (fusion S9 AP-4 D6), Broadside heavy rail (S12+ AP-4 Dev), Twin Lance, 2x Riptide ion accelerator, markerlight support. A markerlit 9" Sunforge/Crisis drop dumps ~25-35 into ONE Knight (fusion D6 + rail Dev bypass the ion shield). Fire-and-Fade neuters melee.

Mission / heist: ['NAVIGATOR DOME IS LOAD-BEARING: the 12" anti-Deep-Strike bubble denies the Sunforge/Crisis 9" drop — the single biggest swing in the matchup. Deploy it central.', 'Kill the Broadside + Riptides at range (Volcano/plasma) before markerlights stack; delete Pathfinders (the mark engine) with the Avenger.', 'Rotate the most-lit Knight each turn; never present a clean un-Rotated focus target; LoS-block the alpha turn.', 'Out-OC on the ground (T'au OC is modest) IF you survive the alpha — steal the primary while their suits reposition.']

Kill priority: Broadside / Riptides (rail+ion) -> Sunforge fusion suits -> markerlight Pathfinders -> Commanders.

Deploy: Navigator dome central; reserves + terrain vs the drop; kill mark/rail platforms first.

Chaos Daemons — >51% (Coin-flip) · you play **Meatgrinder vs their Purge the Foe (they play Meatgrinder)**

Deciding factor: Fast MELEE alpha: 3x Skullmaster + Bloodcrusher Juggernaut cav (T6 W4, charge bonuses) + Bloodthirster (T10 W18 FLY, great axe S16 AP-3 Dev) + Rendmasters. Daemonic 5++ everywhere; charges into the no-melee-invuln Questoris. (Nurgle variant = Plaguebearer grind, slower, out-hold problem not a kill problem.)

Mission / heist: ['Shoot the Bloodcrushers (T6 W4, no armour help — gatling/plasma/RFBC) OFF before they charge; each un-charged Juggernaut pack is ~0 threat.', 'Screen the Bloodthirster's lane; Lancer DUELS it (4++ trades favourably, S20 one-rounds a wounded 'Thirster) rather than eating its charge on a Castellan.', 'Rotate the exposed Knight vs the (modest) ranged; out-OC the cav once thinned.', 'vs Nurgle grind: ignore the tarpit, out-shoot Plaguebearers off objectives, win on tempo.']

Kill priority: Bloodthirster (or screen) -> Bloodcrushers pre-charge -> Skullmasters / Rendmasters.

Deploy: Layer chaff/Armiger vs the charge; keep a Lancer free to counter-punch the cav.

Astra Militarum — 76% (Favourable) · you play **Destroyer's Wrath vs their Priority Assets (they play Vital Link)**

Deciding factor: A SHOOTING brawl in my lane: Baneblade/Banesword/Stormsword (CHARACTER via Steel Hammer) + lascannon sponsons, or Shadowsword (Volcano cannon S16 AP-4 D6+6 — one-shots a Knight) + 3 artillery + Leman Russ. High-S anti-Knight, but the superheavies are KILLABLE (T12-14 W22-24, no invuln) and SLOW.

Mission / heist: ['Win the gun duel: 2x Volcano (S18) out-ranges/out-damages their superheavies — delete the Shadowsword (the one thing that one-shots you) FIRST, then the lascannon platforms.', 'Rotate vs the alpha; hull-down T1; their artillery is indirect (worse into a moving Knight in cover).', 'Out-manoeuver the M9-10 tanks + out-OC (Guard infantry is chaff you gun down); race the mission.', 'This is the matchup the 2-Castellan build is BUILT for — a straight firepower race.']

Kill priority: Shadowsword (Volcano cannon) -> lascannon superheavies -> artillery -> Leontus.

Deploy: Hull-down + Rotate T1; concentrate Volcanoes on the biggest gun each turn.

Space Marines (Iron Hands) — 51% (Coin-flip) · you play **Meatgrinder vs their Purge the Foe (they play Meatgrinder)**

Deciding factor: 10-model Assault Terminator thunder-hammer brick (S8 AP-2 D2, ~12-16 into a no-invuln Questoris on the charge) delivered by deep-strike + Celerity advance-charge, Feirros durability, Ballistus/Repulsor lascannon backfield. The brick is the only real Knight-killer; the rest is chaff/scorers.

Mission / heist: ['Screen the deep-strike (Navigator dome) + shoot the hammer brick BEFORE it lands (Avenger/RFBC into 2W-2+ Terminators — volume forces the 4++).', 'Lancer counter-charges the landed brick (4++ survives hammers a Castellan can't); never feed a Questoris into its charge.', 'Delete the Repulsor/Ballistus (lascannon) + Sternguard with the big guns; out-OC the ~30 bodies.', 'Win on the mission — the brick can't be everywhere; contest what it isn't on with OC10.']

Kill priority: Repulsor/Ballistus (lascannon) -> hammer brick as it lands -> Sternguard -> Scouts.

Deploy: Navigator dome vs the drop; hold the Lancer to counter-charge the brick.

Imperial Fists — 77% (Favourable) · you play **Destroyer's Wrath vs their Priority Assets (they play Vital Link)**

Deciding factor: Unsaveable Sternguard Dev (full wound-reroll vs Oath) + sticky OC10 Intercessors + an OC34 Lysander Terminator brick (NOT battle-shock-immune, but Knights have no way to force a test) + Armour of Contempt + a ~30-34 Oath-convergence alpha. Sisters 98-31 lesson: durable + sticky + volume.

Mission / heist: ['Navigator dome (12" anti-Deep-Strike) blunts his Teleport-Homer / Land-Speeder deep-strike alpha.', 'BREAK the Oath convergence: Volcano/thermal the Land Speeders (deep-strike enablers) + the Sternguard FIRST; firepower-as-denial strips his soft OC.', 'Out-mobile the M5 bricks — his OC34 brick can't be everywhere; contest the objectives it isn't on with OC10 + the Lancer threatening his home.', 'Start from EXPECTATION OF A LOSS; steal via mobility secondaries. Honest coin-flip (~55-56 vs 62 in the hardened sim).']

Kill priority: Land Speeders (enablers) -> Sternguard (unsaveable Dev) -> break the brick's character support.

Deploy: Navigator home-hold + deploy Hidden; don't over-expose to the alpha convergence.

Imperial Knights — 52% (Coin-flip) · you play **Meatgrinder vs their Purge the Foe (they play Meatgrinder)**

Deciding factor: A shooting slugfest that's ~EVEN by definition (it's a mirror): first turn, cover (-1 to hit), and the

Ion-Shield-cycling race decide it. THE KEY: shooting into a Knight gets Ion-Shielded (5++, Rotate 4++), but MELEE does NOT — Questoris/Dominus have no melee invuln — so the efficient kill is the LANCER charging a Castellán (S20, no invuln), not out-shooting the 4++. (Sim note: this reads as B-favoured because more Lancers = the better mirror tool; the absolute is a relative indicator, the real mirror is a coin-flip.)

Mission / heist: ['WIN THE ROLL-OFF / seize — first-turn Volcano into an un-Rotated Castellán is the swing.', 'Rotate Ion Shields onto the focused Knight every turn (4++ vs their Volcanos); fight from cover (-1 to hit).', 'Send the Lancer into a Castellán in MELEE (no invuln there) — that's your most efficient Knight-kill; don't rely on Ion-Shielded shooting.', 'Race the mission — 5 big models each means objectives are decided by positioning + who commits the Lancer.']

Kill priority: Enemy Castelláns (their guns) -> the Lancer -> Armigers. Lancer-assassinate a Castellán in melee.

Deploy: Cover + first-turn positioning; hide the focused Knight; the Navigator holds home.

Imperial Knights — 23% (Unfavourable) · you play **Unstoppable Force vs their Take and Hold (they play Immovable Object)**

Deciding factor: Their two Cerastus Lancers (M14, 4++ ALL-around, S20 AP-3 D8) hunt you, and your shooting into a 4++ Lancer is inefficient. You out-gun them (2 Castelláns vs 1), but killing a fast 4++ Lancer at range before it charges is slow — and your lone Lancer is out-numbered in the melee trade. This is the matchup List B (2 Lancer) is built for; List A is on the back foot.

Mission / heist: ['Focus a Lancer with everything T1-2 (2 Volcanos + Crusader + Helverins) — but expect the 4+ + to drag it out; Rotate + kite the other.', 'Your Lancer counter-charges one of theirs (4++ vs 4++ trade); don't feed a Castellán into their Lancers (no melee invuln = you die).', 'Screen the charge lanes with the Helverin/Crusader; use Super-Heavy Walker to fall-back-and-shoot out of a Lancer's grip.', 'Out-score on the mission while trading — you won't cleanly out-fight two Lancers.']

Kill priority: Enemy Lancers (the M14 melee threat) -> Castellán -> Armigers.

Deploy: Screen the Lancer charge lanes; kite; keep the Castelláns out of the 14"+charge threat.

The list (List A)

Unit	×	Wargear	Pts	Note
Knight Castellán	2	Volcano lance (D3 shots S18 AP-5 D6+8), plasma decimator (D6+3 shots), 2x twin meltagun, 2x shieldbreaker, twin siegebreaker, feet	425 + 450	The shooting core (escalating: 1st 425, 2nd 450). 2x Volcano (D3 shots ea, ~23 dmg) one-shots no-invuln anchors + snipes; plasma decimator anti-elite; +1 hit vs terrain (Dominus). #1 bears Archeotech Autoloaders (re-roll the shot count on the D3/D6+3 guns).
Knight Crusader	1	Rapid-fire battle cannon (D6+3 S10, +15pts), Avenger gatling (A18 S6 AP-2 D2), heavy flamer, thermal cannon (2D3 S12 AP-4 Melta6), stubber, feet	410	395 base + 15 for the RFBC. Anti-infantry SUBTRACTION: RFBC + Avenger A18 strip soft OC; thermal for anti-tank/Speeders.
Cerastus Knight	1	Shock lance — strike 5A S20 AP-3 D8 [Lance] /	415	The one blade: 4++ FULL invuln vs ALL, M14 W28. Counter-charge + kill characters (standalone monsters/Titanic

Lancer		sweep 10A S10 AP-2 D3; ranged shock lance 12" 6A [Assault, Sus2]		DIRECTLY; ATTACHED buff-characters via EPIC CHALLENGE — 1CP core strat granting its melee [PRECISION]) + Shock-Charge free Tank Shock.
Armiger Helverin	1	2x Armiger autocannon (48" A4 S9 AP-1 D3), heavy stubber	140	Backfield 48" autocannon platform — BOND TO THE CRUSADER (Crusader's Duty Bondsman = +1 to hit -> BS2+, 8 shots): consistent anti-infantry/light removal that fills the list's anti-scorer gap. Survivable OC6 home/backfield anchor (you're out-OC'd by most of the field) + Suppression Protocols (-1 to hit its target). Chosen over a Warglaive: the list's anti-tank is already over-solved (2x Volcano + thermal + shieldbreaker + Lancer), so add ranged volume + a body that survives to score, not a fragile forward melee piece that duplicates the Lancer.
Navigator (Agents ally)	1	Gaze of the Empyrean	75	12" anti-Deep-Strike dome (vs BA/SW/GSC/deep-strike alphas) + Hidden home-holder. Allies take no enhancement. (75 confirmed from Scott Ketcham's Tacoma roster.)